

# STORMS CARRY HOPE, WORRY FOR L.A.

Rain may end the fire season, but too much could cause debris flows in burn areas.

BY RONG-GONG LIN II,  
JULIA WICK  
AND HANNAH FRY

Back-to-back atmospheric rivers are expected to hit Southern California this week, raising hopes of a definitive end to a catastrophic fire season, while also heightening concerns about debris flows in the region's burn scar areas.

The first atmospheric river is set to peak in Los Angeles and Ventura counties Tuesday night and last through midday Wednesday, with the second storm forecast to hit Thursday night and last into Friday morning.

Both storms are expected to drop light-to-moderate rain, falling at a rate that should produce only minor impacts. There is a less than 5% chance of rain falling at a rate so intense that it could trigger significant mud and debris flows in Los Angeles and Ventura counties, said Todd Hall, a meteorologist with the National Weather Service in Oxnard.

Still, officials have warned residents whose neighborhoods were devastated by the Palisades and Eaton fires last month to remain on alert. Some of the heaviest rain in Los Angeles County is expected to fall during Wednesday's early morning hours and late Thursday into Friday morning, Hall said.

"We're going to have to see how this evolves. The second storm could bring maybe a little higher potential [for mud and debris flows] for Eaton and Palisades, but we're going to keep monitoring that as we move through this week," Hall said.

Rainfall has the potential to be particularly focused on south-facing mountain slopes and hillsides, because of the path of the moisture arriving in the region, Hall said. This is a concern because [See Rain, A10]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

**CITY WORKERS** erected fencing along Alvarado Street near MacArthur Park after a shooting injured six people. One goal was to stop the sale of illegal drugs, but some vendors say they are just trying to make a living.

## Crime, commerce take hits at MacArthur Park

Los Angeles erects barriers on Westlake sidewalks to crack down on gangs and illegal activity, but street vendors are sidelined too

STEVE LOPEZ

On Alvarado Street, where the vending corridor across from MacArthur Park has long been a defining feature of the neighborhood, something is missing.

The vendors.

For years, they've been setting up tables on neighborhood sidewalks each day and stacking them with clothing, electronics, medication, toiletries, laundry detergent and other goods. But almost immediately after an early morning gang-related shooting on Jan. 22, in which six people were injured, L.A. Mayor Karen Bass called for city workers to erect barriers and for police to step up patrols.

"LAPD surged resources into MacArthur Park at the direction of the mayor — increasing a visible foot-



beat presence and making arrests for suspected gang-related activity," Bass spokesman Zach Seidl said Friday in a statement. "The fencing has helped disrupt the illegal sales of drugs and weapons along with halting the associated violence in the area. The mayor looks forward to working with community leaders and Councilwoman [Eunisses] Hernandez on a safe and legal way for vendors to vend in the MacArthur Park community."

The Westlake neighborhood has been the center of a raging drug and homelessness epidemic that has driven families out of the park and affected the quality of life for thousands of impoverished, working-class residents. Gutters are littered with trash and syringes. Drug-ravaged people [See Lopez, A7]

## Dam releases didn't help farms, L.A.

Trump's 'beautiful water flow' perplexes many. Critics say it was a political ploy.

BY IAN JAMES,  
JESSICA GARRISON  
AND SEAN GREENE

Days after President Trump startled some of his

most ardent supporters in California's San Joaquin Valley by having the Army Corps of Engineers suddenly release water from two dams, many in the region and beyond were still perplexed.

Acting on an order from Washington, the corps allowed irrigation water to flow down river channels for three days, into the network of engineered waterways

that fan out among farm fields in the San Joaquin Valley. Coursing from rivers to canals to irrigation ditches, much of the water eventually made its way to retention basins, where it soaked into the ground, replenishing groundwater.

"It's been recharged to the ground," said Tom Barcellos, president of the Lower Tule River Irrigation District and a dairyman and

farmer. That sounds good, except farmers in parts of the San Joaquin Valley typically depend on water from the two dams to irrigate crops in the summer. In other words, the release of water this time of year, when agriculture usually doesn't require it, means that growers are likely to have less water stored in the reservoirs this summer, during a year [See Dam releases, A5]

## Push is on for California to expedite fire safety rules

Lawmakers call for state guidelines on ember-resistant zones around homes.

BY ALEX WIGGLESWORTH

California lawmakers are calling on the state to expedite rules that some scientists and fire officials say might have helped mitigate the damage from Los Angeles' devastating wildfires.

The idea is simple: By keeping the first 5 feet around a home clear of flammable vegetation, wooden fencing and debris, homeowners can reduce the risk of embers igniting their property — and, with that, the chances of an urban conflagration in which flames spread from structure to structure.

The California Legislature in 2020 passed a bill requiring property owners in fire-prone areas to maintain so-called ember-resistant zones around their homes. The legislation tasked the Board of Forestry and Fire Protection with writing up rules governing exactly what this should look like by Jan. 1, 2023. But the board still hasn't done so, and doesn't have a firm timeline for when they'll be finished.

Asked why the rule-making is more than two years behind schedule, board Executive Officer Edith Hannigan responded with a statement saying the agency is still in the "pre-rule-making phase" of developing the standards and is focused on finding options for financial assistance and education to help people comply with them.

[See Rules, A10]



BRIAN VAN DER BRUG Los Angeles Times

**THE GOAL** of an ember-resistant zone is to cut property connections, lowering the risk of flames spreading. Above, a home burns Jan. 7 in Pacific Palisades.

## Canada, Mexico tariffs placed on hold

Nations and Trump reach 11th-hour deals. But U.S. duties on China may kick in.

BY KATE LINTHICUM  
AND PATRICK J.  
MCDONNELL

MEXICO CITY — Mexico and Canada have managed to avoid U.S. tariffs — for now — after their leaders came to last-minute agreements with President Trump. But barring another late-hour deal, tariffs on goods from China were scheduled to go into force Tuesday, raising the specter of a trade war that could roil the global economy and punish American consumers.

Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum and Trump said Monday that they had come to an accord that delays for at least a month the U.S. president's threat of 25% tariffs on all Mexican goods imported by the United States.

Mexico promised to reinforce its northern border with 10,000 national guard members in order to combat migration and the trafficking of illegal drugs. The country has long stationed thousands of troops along its northern border. It sent about 15,000 members of its armed forces there in 2019, the last time Trump threatened — but then walked back — tariffs.

In Canada, Prime Minister Justin Trudeau said tariffs on goods from his country had also been averted for at least one month. He said on X that Canada would also fortify its border with the U.S. with "new choppers, technology and personnel" and would appoint a "Fentanyl Czar."

On Saturday, Trump [See Tariffs, A5]

### California catches a break for now

Tariffs on Mexico, Canada would hurt consumers, companies in various ways. **BUSINESS, A6**

### Not won over by 'Emilia Pérez'

Near-empty screening rooms suggest a mostly hostile — if not indignant — Mexican audience. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

### Beyoncé gets her Grammys due

The singer finally wins the prestigious album of the year, a sign of systemic change. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

### Home insurer seeks rate hikes

State Farm says it's in dire financial straits because of claims from Los Angeles-area wildfires. **BUSINESS, A6**

**Weather**  
Partly sunny.  
L.A. Basin: 65/54. **B6**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.

Printed with soy inks on partially recycled paper.



Get more of the news you need.  
Download the app.

